

Managing modifiers

A MODIFIER IS A WORD, PHRASE, OR CLAUSE THAT DESCRIBES ANOTHER WORD, PHRASE, OR CLAUSE.

Used correctly, modifiers make sentences more descriptive and therefore more interesting. If a modifier is put in the wrong place in a sentence, however, it can alter the whole meaning of that sentence.

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Misplaced adverbs

Common one-word modifiers include the adverbs *only*, *almost*, *just*, and *nearly*. These adverb modifiers are usually placed right before the word they modify. If a modifier is in the wrong place, the intended meaning may not be clear, and the modifier may end up modifying the wrong person or thing.

This means that I spoke to Maria very recently, and asked her to lunch.

I **just** asked Maria to lunch.

This means that I asked Maria to lunch, and no one else.

I asked **just** Maria to lunch.

This means that I was tempted to eat a whole pie, but I didn't eat any of it.

I **almost** ate a whole pie.

This means that I ate the pie, and ate most of it.

I ate **almost** a whole pie.

The comedian Groucho Marx **humorously** used a **misplaced modifier**: “One morning I shot an elephant **in my pajamas**. How he got into my pajamas I’ll never know.”

Misplaced adjectives

Like adverb modifiers, adjective modifiers should be placed as close as possible to the person or thing they describe. Misplaced adjectives tend to occur when a noun is described by several words.

This adjective is describing a silver woman, not a silver bracelet.

Jim found a **silver** woman's bracelet.



Jim found a woman's **silver** bracelet.

The adjective is now describing a silver bracelet that belongs to a woman.



GLOSSARY

Dangling participle When a modifying phrase or clause that starts with a participle is put in the wrong place in a sentence, it is described as “dangling,” because it has no subject to hold on to.

Main clause A group of words that contains a subject and a verb and makes complete sense on its own.

Misplaced modifier A modifier that has been placed so far from the person or thing it is intended to modify that it appears to modify a different person or thing.

Participle The form of a verb that ends in -ing (present participle) or -ed or -en (past participle).

Subject The person or thing that is performing the action of the verb.

Subordinate clause A group of words that contains a subject and a verb but depends on a main clause for its meaning.